



**Mother and baby homes (including
pre-1948 Workhouses) and
Magdalene laundries oral history
project**

Interview with TY

Anonymous (TY)

14th November 2018

Location: Queen's University Belfast

Interviewed by Olivia Dee

Transcribed by Sam Manning and Jack Crangle

TY went to a Good Shepherd mother and baby home when she was pregnant in the late 1960s. She was 20 years old at that time and studying at university. Initially, she travelled to England with her boyfriend before her sister asked for advice from a priest who suggested that TY consider adoption for her baby. He advised that TY hide her pregnancy from her parents by staying in one of the Good Shepherd mother and baby institutions in Northern Ireland. TY's Sister and the Good Shepherd Sisters enabled her to keep the pregnancy secret from her parents by creating the impression that TY was still in England, pursuing studies connected to her university degree. TY explained that she was well treated by the Good Shepherd Sisters, reasoning that her status as a university student may have been a factor in this regard. TY was instructed not to reveal her surname to the other women. She recalled being well fed whilst in the mother and baby home and thought that the chores she was asked to do were not unreasonable. These chores ended once she had given birth, after which she took turns, along with all the other new mothers, to sleep in the nursery with all the new-born babies. TY's baby was adopted, although she recalls that the nuns offered to look after the baby until she married her boyfriend. However, TY felt unable to do because she could not face revealing the pregnancy to her parents. She remembers that each Sunday prospective adoptive parents visited the baby home's parlour where they viewed infants for potential adoption. TY's adopted daughter reunited with her when she was in her mid-twenties and TY discussed the strong emotions that this raised in her family. TY remained in contact with Sister W, one of the Good Shepherd nuns, in the years following her daughter's

birth and has a good relationship with her. For this reason and because of her good treatment in the home, TY readily agreed to a request from another nun to offer testimony to the researchers.

Names and details of locations are redacted in order to protect TY's identity and that of her family and others mentioned in her interview. Redactions are indicated by **. The baby's birth father, who TY married, is identified here as BF. The baby girl is identified here as AD.

OD: Alright, perfect. So just for the tape, I'll just say I am Olivia Dee and we are in Queen's University and it's the 14th November...

TY: 14th.

OD: ... thank you, 2018. And we're part of the Northern Ireland Mother and Baby Homes and Magdalene Laundries project. And I'm here with an interviewee who is going to talk to me about her connection with those institutions. So, if you're happy I can just ask you a couple of questions and...

TY: Fire away.

OD: Yeah, okay, perfect. So can you tell me first of all, whatever you're happy to kind of discuss about why it is that you went to ... can you tell me first of all, sorry, what mother and baby home it was that you went to.

TY: It was *name of Good Shepherd mother and baby home and location*.

OD: ... perfect. And what, kind of, brought you to *Good Shepherd mother and baby home*?

TY: Well, I got pregnant to ... I was twenty at the time and my then boyfriend, now husband, was eighteen and I got pregnant and kept thinking I wasn't, I wasn't. And one thing I knew was I couldn't go home. Not that my parents would turn me out, there's no way they'd have done that, but I was one of the first generation of working-class people who got free education.

OD: Right.

TY: And then, if you were pregnant and had a baby, nobody ever stayed on at uni, they left and had to get married. Now *BF* had said to me: 'Whatever you want to do, we'll get married or whatever you want to do.' And I just knew I couldn't tell my father because he had, he'd actually encouraged me to go on to uni. Mummy would have sent me out to work after A-levels, but he says: "No, let her go, let her go. It'll never go to waste." He was very much for women's education then, that was *date in late 1960s*, you know.

OD: Wow.

TY: Which was good. So, I went to uni and my dates worked that I could go in and work for the summer and they wouldn't know.

OD: Right.

TY: I had worked the previous year in *location in England*, so I'd worked in a *high street shop* ... with other girls who I'd gone to school with. So, I went to *location in England* and I worked in *high street shop* there, for a couple of

months until I began to show. And the girl I was sharing with knew, nobody else knew. Nobody at home knew at that time. And *BF* was staying with his uncle, working for him. And then when I started to show, I left work and pretended that I was going back to Ireland.

OD: Okay.

TY: But I stayed in *location in England*, didn't know what I was going to do, had no idea what I was going to do. *BF*, for such a young boy, he had just turned nineteen then, he made me go to my antenatal He made me look after myself. And the social worker there, whenever the idea of adoption come up, I thought that would be my way out. And she suggested I come back to Ireland to a mother and baby home rather than England. Because she says, it was ... I can't remember what she actually [said], but it was something like the adoption services were better or whatever. So, she arranged for me to come to *location of Good Shepherd mother and baby home* and at that time I thought: but how, my parents think I'm in *location in England*. And she says: "You can write to them, send the letter to me, and I will forward it to them."

OD: Wow, what a schemer at eighteen.

TY: What a schemer, yeah. So, she arranged that so that my parents thought I was, would you believe I told them, a field trip in *another location in England*. Don't know why I picked [that location]. I just looked at the map And they had no idea, of course, what a field trip was.

OD: Yeah.

TY: Do you know, they [her parents] just, whatever I said, that was fine. And I had resits to do. I had failed my exams, I had resits to do. But *name of university* sent my papers to *university in England* and enabled me to do my resits there.

OD: Wow.

TY: And I think if I'd written nothing on the paper they would have passed me. Do you know, I really do. So, it would be the end of September, I think, I flew to Belfast. Now I'd told one sister at home and she met me at the airport. Her and her husband met *BF* and I at the airport, dropped him off in *name of town* where he lived and took me ... to *Good Shepherd mother and baby home*. And...

OD: Wow.

TY: Yeah. And I remember looking out the window of the car and he's standing at the corner of his street and he's smoking, lighting up this cigarette and the look on his face, I'll never forget, it was 'aahhh, oh I don't have to worry about her anymore.' You know, it was just that look on his face and that there and I was crying my eyes out thinking 'oh, it's all over for you, but I have it all ahead of me', you know. But, so we went down to *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* and my sister and her husband, they dropped me off and the nuns brought me into the parlour and took all your details and everything and, you know, a wee bit of disapproval in the voice, but, you know, they were going to sort me out anyway. So, I was given a private room. Now at that time I thought my sister had paid for that, but she hadn't. There were about maybe four or five single rooms and there was, I think, one dormitory. I'm not sure, there might have been two dormitories where most of the girls stayed. Now I think there

was a wee bit of snobbishness in that I was educated. I think that's why I got the single room, I don't know. But I had a wee single room with my own bed and a wardrobe, table. The other girls in the dormitories, I don't think I was ever actually ... oh wait, I must have been in the dormitory after *AD* was born. But you got three meals a day, you were fed. It was warm, it was comfortable. And we had to do a wee bit of maybe polishing and stuff. Those of us who hadn't had our babies did a wee bit of housework, but it wasn't that you were ... you had nothing else to, it occupied the time. You had a table that you sat at for your meals and I remember us actually having a bit of fun, do you know, between yourselves. Nobody knew anybody's surname.

OD: Right.

TY: Just first names. And the nuns allowed *BF* to write to me. I would get my letter face down beside my breakfast table when he wrote, which I thought was really good.

OD: Did they read it?

TY: No.

OD: Oh, good.

TY: It was unopened, unopened. And they allowed me to write to him. So that was great, that was a comfort because it was like a lonely time, if you know what I mean, even though you had the girls.

OD: Yeah, I can imagine.

TY: As I said, we were fed. Once you had your baby, you looked after your baby. You had no housework to do or dishes or anything like that. You looked after your baby and you took turns in the nursery at night. I think I only did it twice. I was only there after *AD* was born for about three-and-a-half weeks. Usually you stayed for six weeks, but because I had to get back to uni, they facilitated me and they'd obviously... *AD* [adoptive] mum and dad were already arranged for that. You looked after your baby during the day: fed your baby, changed her and then at night you took turns in the nursery. You slept in the bed in the nursery. And then when a baby awoke, you went in and got the mother and she would feed the baby during the night.

OD: And were you breastfeeding or bottle-feeding?

TY: Oh, you weren't allowed to breastfeed, nobody was allowed to breastfeed – bottle-fed.

OD: Why was that? Was that because you would be leaving?

TY: That was ... I don't know, but it was just, I think it would be because you'd be leaving because most babies were adopted after six weeks.

OD: Yeah, so it was probably safer...

TY: ... But I remember one Sunday, people would come to the parlour on a Sunday to adopt babies and your baby was brought up. Now, if they decided to take the baby, I can't remember whether they went there and then with the adopted parents or whether you'd, they came back and then they came during the week or something...: So, so you looked after your baby during the night. You took your turn in the, like the washroom doing the nappies, you know,

maybe twice a week or something, or whatever. It depended on the number of girls who were there. And they arranged that I could go back after three-and-half weeks. I ... the ... taxi and I took her up to *location* and she was left off in the *name of baby home* there. And then I went straight home in the same taxi and pretended that I was just off the boat, from my field trip.

OD: You must have been exhausted.

TY: Well, all I could think of Livi was ‘I’ve gotten away with this.’ That was my initial thought, ‘I’ve actually gotten away with it.’

OD: Yeah.

TY: And after that all the guilt sets in, but then and everything. Oh God, I couldn’t wait to get back to uni. And I remember thinking *BF will not be at this bus, this train station. He’ll be so glad it’s all over. He’ll be away like a shot.’ But he wasn’t, he was there waiting for me.

OD: And he stayed with you.

TY: Yeah, that’s good. But no, the nuns actually offered to look after *AD* for me until I married *BF*, if I wanted to do that. But I just says: “I can’t tell Daddy.”

OD: Yeah.

TY: I couldn’t have because I’d have still have had to leave. And even his parents, and he was eighteen, how could I face them ... to give up his university career. All of that, you know, so...

OD: Absolutely.

TY: But, no it was just the relief that I'd got away with it. That was my initial thought, 'I've gotten away with this. They don't know.' And they didn't know until she came back.

OD: Wow. And when did she come back?

TY: When she was twenty-six. She was *age* last week.

OD: So, wow, so when she was twenty-six was that after the law had changed? Did she find you?

TY: Well, you see, because she was adopted in the North, she could find me at any time. If you were adopted in the South you couldn't, you see. But I remember *BF* and I, I mean her birthday was the *date*, we used to always celebrate it, you know. Lift a wee glass and say: "I wonder where she's bopping tonight?" And that sort of thing. And at eighteen I was sure she'd appear at the door, I was positive she'd appear. She didn't. I thought 'well maybe she'll wait until she's twenty-one. Twenty-one, she'll definitely ...' And *BF* always used to say to me "TY we can't look for her. It's not our place to do that. We'd interfere in her life. If she needs us, she'll come and look for us." But behind his back, I went to see a social worker and ... I said to her: "Can you find out where she is for me?"

She says: "Oh yeah, no problem."

I says: "Oh, great."

She says: "But there's two things you would have to be prepared for."

And I went: "What's that?"

She says: “One thing, she mightn’t like you.”

And I went: “Of course she will, I’m her mother. She’ll love me, I’m her mother.’

And the other thing she said, which changed my mind, was: “She might not have had a happy life.”

So, when she told me that I thought ‘oh, I couldn’t cope with that. Don’t look for her. Don’t look for her.’ If she had come back and said that, I don’t know what I’d have done.

OD: Yeah, I can imagine.

TY: But she did, she was a spoiled cat [Laughs]. She was spoiled from the day they, they took her. And I left her up on *date* and she was adopted the next day.

OD: Yeah.

TY: They’d obviously earmarked her mum and dad. And her mum and dad had adopted a boy before that and they told her that *name of adoptive father* picked her. So, isn’t that nice?

OD: That’s lovely. I can understand the idea that it must ... the decision to make, you know, to try and find someone must be very, very difficult.

TY: Yeah, because they’re not ... and I used to be driving back home from work and stuff and I’d be thinking – telepathic - I believe it a lot and used to say ‘come on, what’s keeping you? Hurry up, hurry up’, you know. But as she has said since she come out, she’s like: “Really Mum”, she says ‘if I had come [to

find TY when] younger, I don't know if I'd have coped the same." She says: "eighteen would have been too young, so would twenty-one", do you know? Now, the year before she found us her mum died.

OD: Right.

TY: Her mum was on the heart transplant list and they had a heart ... *AD* works in *workplace in the RoI*... And they said 'we've got a heart for your mother' and they tried to phone her father, he was travelling in the west of Ireland. Tried to phone the brother who lived up there in *name of RoI town*, that's where she was reared, in *town*. No answer. So, they said to *AD* "Look, you need to go up. We've got a heart for your mother." And when she went up, she couldn't get in and her mum had dropped dead in the hall with the shock of it; getting ready to go.

OD: Yeah.

TY: So that was very traumatic for her. That was the year before she found us. Now, she will say it wasn't a replacement. I don't think it was, but I would say she maybe didn't want to hurt her mum too, you know. Although her mum used to say to her: "When are we going to look for your birth mother? We'll go down the *redacted* coast there and see if we can..." Because I'd left my sister's address with the authorities, the sister that knew [about the pregnancy].

OD: Yeah.

TY: And I knew she wasn't going to be moving. So, her mum and dad were very upfront for those times, you know, very modern in that they always told

her she was adopted and they'd picked her and, you know, that was all really good for her then, you know.

OD: It just sounds so, I don't know, so ... everything interlocked perfectly.

TY: Well over the years, as I say, we've been ... only when she came back did the guilt really hit me. And she, after she lost her mum, and unfortunately, she came back the *date* and her dad died on the *date* that year. Her mum had just died the year before and her dad was coming back from a funeral ... and he was in a car accident. And he died on *date*. So, we never met him. I wrote to him, I managed to write to him and say that I wasn't going to interfere in their life or upset things. But, you know, she [AD] was lovely and all the rest of it. And he was planning to have us down to visit.

OD: That's really sad.

TY: He was going to have us down. He was saying to his sister and all. But that never happened, so she came up to us a lot after that. She obviously needed us. And *BF* and I reacted completely differently to that. I dreaded her coming up. I dreaded her coming up. I couldn't look at her. And yet I kept thinking 'this is awful, you rejected this child, how can you do it again?' and covered that up. Whereas *BF* was completely obsessed. He couldn't stop looking at her. She'd go to the toilet and he'd be sat outside the bathroom waiting on her coming out. He followed her after. When we were out anywhere, he had to sit beside her, nearly on top of her. Right, and she would go away, he goes all agitated until she comes back again. And that made me feel even worse. I remember thinking 'how can you get on like that?' Like Jesus, God, and Mary I couldn't believe it because I was reacting and he couldn't understand how I was behaving.

OD: Yeah.

TY: Because I'd rejected her when she was a baby and this was the same thing. So luckily, we went to counselling.

OD: Oh, what, the three of you together or just the two?

TY: No, I went first. I went to counselling, I thought 'I'm going to kill myself here if I don't do something about it.' So I went to counselling and the counsellor was great. I went to a couple of sessions, two or three, and she says 'you're going to have to go back and live her life through the years.' I thought I can accept that and *AD* was going to counselling for the bereavement of her mum and dad anyway, and she [the counsellor] said:

"And you're going to have to tell her how you feel."

I says: "I can't do that. I can't tell this child that I rejected as a baby that I dread her coming up."

She says: "She'll understand."

I says: "No, she won't."

She says: "She will, she'll understand."

So, I told her and she did. She said: "That's fine Mum. I can understand that."

But she, as I said, she went to counselling, she admitted she needed all that attention which *BF* was giving her. And I thought 'how am I going to get him to go to the counsellor? He needs it.' I mean he was just out of it. Even people when we'd go to the pub and she's there, there was like another woman. This was like another woman in my life, you know that way. It really was like another woman. And everybody's looking at the carry-on of him, nearly sitting on top of her, you know it really was weird. So, our other daughter *name of younger daughter* ... she was the only daughter, I have a daughter and two sons, she's watching all this. She was at ... she was actually living around the

corner from *TY' daughter* in *location* ... and she was actually living more or less round the corner, about fifteen minutes away.

OD: Wow.

TY: Isn't that weird? But I remember thinking '*youngest daughter's name*', how are you coping with this?' Because she was watching her daddy fascinated by this other girl. And her words, which I've never forgotten, were: 'Mum, what I'm going through is nothing compared with what *AD* went through.'

So, I says: "Well, what about your daddy?" I says: "We're going to have to do something about him. Look at the state of him."

And she said: "I'll ask him to go to counselling. I'll say to him.'

Because when I would say to him, he'd say: "There's nothing wrong. It's you.

Why do you not want her coming up? It's yours, not mine [the problem]."

So, there was a whole ... things weren't good then, even though when she came up we were ... everything was lovely and it was great. But I was going through turmoil and he was just on another world. So, he went to counselling once I think, or twice, and he was fine after that.

OD: Wow. [both laugh]

TY: Now he still would favour her. He wouldn't have a word said against her. Like, I'd say about '*youngest daughter's name*': "our daughter is very laid back, my God, she needs to get her act together." And he would go "Aye, I know that". But you couldn't say anything about AD at all. He still will not say a word about her, so...

OD: So, AD is now *age*.

TY: She's *age* there on *date*.

OD: Wow, so she was born in 196*.

TY: 196*, yes.

OD: Wow.

TY: And when she came back, she married a local guy where we lived, whose [school] class she'd have been in had we'd kept her. Now how's that for weird.

OD: Very.

TY: Coincidence, like. *son-in-law's name*, we knew him. We knew him longer than we knew her.

OD: It sounds like she was just meant to go away for a while but then come back, doesn't it?

redacted section

OD: Did you know she was going to come back?

TY: I always felt she was, but then that again that's you're hoping. Do you know? And all you wanted to do was to explain why. And when she, we got word on *date* and I, apparently she'd contacted the social worker ... a social worker, and they couldn't find my marriage licence or anything, and they thought I'd emigrated.

OD: Oh wow.

TY: But they had my sister's address. So, they contacted - sent a letter to her. And she phoned me up on the Friday and said: "You need to come in here". I lived three miles from her – and I says: "Oh, it's Friday, I'm getting the dinner ready" ... 'You need to come in.' And I remember thinking 'oh my god.' And we went in and she had a letter from the social worker saying she needed to contact me, and did my sister know where I was living? So, she phoned, said; "She's living out the road from me, three miles." And I met her [the social worker] on the Monday. I phoned her up. And she said: "Your daughter *AD* is looking for tracing you."

[Section redacted explaining the choice of name for *AD* and that, luckily, her adoptive parents kept the same name (many other parents change it)]

OD: Did they yeah?

TY: Yeah they, I didn't know that. But I wrote to her on the Sunday. That was the Friday when I heard and I sat down and I wrote a letter to give to the social worker on the Monday for her. And the day I wrote that letter was Mother's Day. It's funny all of these things, it was the *date*.

OD: Lots of little bits of magic in it isn't there?

TY: And I said to her that I was married and she had a sister and two brothers, and I'd actually written two letters over the years and left them up in the mother and baby home [see below, TY meant a baby home]. Whenever her brothers were born and to tell her where I was living if she ever came to look for me. But

they had, they had filed those under *name redacted – this name was a mistake*.

OD: Is that your maiden name?

TY: My name's *surname*.

OD: Oh, of course yeah.

TY: So, when she was looking for me they hadn't got those to give her. But she got them eventually, they found it eventually, so she was able to see that I had been looking for her.

OD: And which home was that?

TY: That was in the *location*.

OD: *Name*?

TY: *Baby home name*... there, and, because that's where she was adopted from. I came up in the taxi that day and left here there and that's where she was adopted from.

OD: The stories are amazing.

TY: It is. It is.

redacted section

OD: Could I ask you a couple of questions?

TY: Sure.

OD: Yeah. So, you really clearly kind of laid out what happened, and I was just wondering, with the concept of adoption, was that, who kind of gave you that idea? Was that something you were pretty sold on anyway?

TY: No, it wasn't. I was, I was in *location in England* and I'd stopped working and I was staying in the wee bedsit with my friend, and then she was going off to Spain and *BF* came over. And, didn't know what I was going to do, and I wrote to my sister at home and told her, and said 'look, you tell mum and dad, but I'm not going home ... I'm not going home.' Right. Because I didn't want them to see me pregnant. And I didn't know what we were gonna do. Now afterwards *BF* has often said to me: "You know, we probably could have managed keeping her." Worked and, you know, lived there and stuff. But I think it was the whole thing that, I was letting Daddy down, you know.

OD: Yeah, no that's...

TY: I was the first of all the chil-, all the families on both sides to go to university. And working-class people then were only getting going then from that 1947 Education Act, you know.

OD: Is that what you would say that your family was, sort of working class?

TY: Oh yeah. Daddy was a *skilled manual occupation*, working class. And, as I say, I went to grammar school – got my Eleven Plus, went to grammar school – O-Levels. I was the first in my family to do A-Levels, A-Levels, even though

I had three older sisters, they didn't do A-Levels. But I went on and did A-Levels, and I thought 'yeah, university, great fun, I'll enjoy it', which it was because we were getting away from home, you know. Went mad.

OD: No but that's, it's really understandable because even if your parents are supportive you still, the pressure of that would be enormous even if they don't put that pressure on you.

TY: Yeah.

OD: It's not to let someone down...

TY: So, Mummy ... thought I was just going out to work, and Daddy says ... "Let her go, that'll not go to waste." He was very proud of that.

OD: And it was free?

TY: It was free and I, my grant Olivia, which was something like £300 a term. I paid my accommodation, my food, I bought my clothes, I fed myself, and I sent my mother home money out of that every term. That's how much your grant did for you. I didn't have to work during my university years. I worked in the summer. I worked in *overseas location* a couple of summers, went off there and worked a couple of summers as a student there, and worked in *location in England*. But, you know, during the year you were able to ... do you know, it was some difference isn't there? Now, God love the students like, you know, it's so difficult for them now, you know.

OD: Oh, I know. I'm very envious of that.

TY: Yeah, I know. I'm sure you are.

OD: So, your sister was the one who suggested...?

TY: She was, well, you see when I was – I went off track there – when I said to her, I says: “Can you tell her?” She says: “I’ll go up and tell Mummy and Daddy.” So, she actually had gone up to *parents’ home location* – she lived *sister’s home location* – she went up to tell them and they were away visiting another aunt. So, she came home and she went to her local priest to ask his advice. And he said: “Has she thought of adoption? This is a way she could keep it from her parents.” I remember thinking “Yes.” And then I discussed this with the social worker at the anti-natal.

OD: Got it. And she suggested to come here?

TY: And she said come to Ireland, the facilities are better.

OD: So, if your parents hadn’t, had have been there, would she have told ... was it just luck that they happened to be away so she went to the priest?

TY: Yeah.

OD: So, they would have known.

TY: They, they would have known.

OD: Wow.

TY: And what the nuns allowed me in *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* to do was, every - mum and dad used to go to ... down to visit my sister *sister's home location* on like a ... every Sunday. And the nuns allowed me to go into their parlour and phone my sister from *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* ... and mum and dad come on and thought I was phoning from *location in England* ... "And when are you coming home?"... "I don't know, this trip's lasting a long time." They had no idea what was happening, I hadn't even a clue of my dates, I didn't know how long I'd be there. Well... "No, I've been in touch with the university, it's fine, they say that the field trip is, you know, relevant to, you know..." ... talked and all that, can't remember what I said but...

OD: What were you supposed to be doing?

TY: ... field trip.

OD: In *location in England*? [both laugh]

TY: I just happened to look at the map, and it wasn't far from *English city* you see, I didn't know what, because I remember that year when I was [there] an uncle died ... and daddy was over at the funeral, and he sent me a card ... said 'I'll maybe come down and see you.' And I remember thinking 'oh dear God.' And then I prayed - I don't anymore I tell you that - but I used to pray then. I remember praying like mad, 'do not come down' - and he didn't.

OD: Wow.

TY: So again, if he'd come down and seen me, what was I going to do? He'd have taken me by the ear and taken me home, you know. He would've like.

OD: Yeah. I just can't imagine the pressure of that first, what, seven, six seven months of being pregnant, of trying to hide it.

TY: Trying to hide it...

OD: Of calling, of sending postcards.

TY: Trying to hide it, because even when I was still in the bedsit with *name of friend* [and], the girls that we were working with in *name*, they were from all the schools, wouldn't even ... we were sitting there, and the bell rang downstairs, and some of the girls came round to see *name of friend*, and I'm there. So, I had to go down and hide in the bathroom for two hours 'til they went. Do you know? It was all that. And yet, whenever *name of friend* left and *BF* came over, *BF* and I were ... it was like a wee ... we were sort of a wee cocooned marriage we were in, you know?

OD: Yeah.

TY: We used to go out every day, do our shopping. We used to go to the library and study for both resits. We used to go to the park, you know, cook together. And knit, I used to knit vests for her, and I taught *BF* to knit as well and he would knit. So it was, it was actually quite idyllic at the time because you just blocked everything out.

OD: Yeah.

TY: Didn't think about what was going to happen.

OD: And so, you felt relieved about the idea of adoption. That was the fix?

TY: Oh yeah. That was actually the, the, the bedsit I was in ... the landlord one day said to me, the owner – some woman who lived in *a different location* – had seen you coming in and out, wants to talk to you. And I thought ‘oh flip’, seeing that I was pregnant. So, I can’t remember, she must’ve been about in her fifties or something. Like, you know at that age I was twenty, twenty-one, she looked, you know I mean anybody over thirty looked forty, fifty. So I don’t know what age she was, but she said: “What are you doing with, when your baby...?”

And I said: “I don’t know”... at that stage I hadn’t thought about what I was going...

And she says: “I would like to adopt your baby.”

And I remember thinking ah, this is my way out, this is... And I says: “Oh right, okay.’

She says: “Yeah, I live in *location* and I would like to adopt your baby.”

So, we discussed everything, and I said something about “Well look, whenever she’s born” - I’m thinking we’re going into an ordinary hospital, you see, I hadn’t thought of a mother and baby home then – “I would like to breastfeed her for a while.”

She says: “Oh no, you can’t do that if I’m adopting her.”

“Right, right.” So that was fine, we discussed it. And then I got “BF*”; here’s me: “She wants to adopt her.”

Now this is a boy who just turned nineteen. He says: “No, if we’re gonna do this, we’re gonna do it right ... There’s something wrong there. Why could she not adopt a baby up to now?” Which I’d never thought of. He says: “there’s something, no...’

OD: Not right...

TY: “No, we’ve gotta do it right for her.” And then she [the landlady] told me I had to leave the bedsit.

OD: Oh.

TY: Mmmhmm. Had to get out. And I thought ‘what am I going to do?’ *BF* was working away *location in the same city* with his uncle, who didn’t know that I was pregnant either, and one of our friends that we’d shared with at university - *friend’s name*, he was in, he’d lived in *another English city* ... he came down to see me, and I says: “You’re gonna have to pretend you’re my husband and we’re gonna look for a new bedsit.” So, he wandered round ... with me, linked me, and we got – in *address*– then we got a bedsit at the top, it was a wee Scottish woman. So, we got another bedsit to stay in. So, it was quite...

OD: I think you’re quite ingenious, the amount of...

TY: I some - I look back and I think ‘how did I cope with all that?’ But you do you see.

OD: It’s exhausting, just the amount of trying, I don’t know, it seems very...

TY: Yeah, it’s hiding it, you know.

OD: But I completely understand why you felt...

TY: Yeah, couldn’t do that to Daddy, he was so proud, so proud.

OD: So, when you arrived in *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* had you ever been to *location* before?

TY: No ... I'd never been in it, no.

OD: So, who took you there?

TY: My sister and her husband met us at the airport ... *BF* and I. Dropped *BF* off – he lived in *name of town* – to his home, at the bottom of his road because his parents didn't know either and then drove me on down. I remember I was sick the whole way down, [whispers] sick, sick, sick.

OD: Like anxious or physically?

TY: Nothing to be sick, almost just retching. They'd stopped the car and I was, oh, and I was sick the day I left *AD* up as well, all the way up in the taxi, and the taxi driver had to stop. I think it was just nerves, you know, the whole thought of it.

OD: Yeah. And your adrenaline at that point must have just ... like eight months of adrenaline.

TY: Oh my God, I know.

OD: So, you arrived and you said there was a little bit of, kind of, disapproval.

TY: Well, this is it, you know. You know, 'you've been a bold girl', right.

OD: Bold?

TY: Well, bold, you know, that sort of thing. I don't know whether they actually used that word but that was the...

OD: That kind of...

TY: That was what they were saying. Now you had to go to, I can't remember if I had to go to Mass every morning, but we certainly had to go every week, and we had to go to confession every week. Now what had you to confess? We were making up that I had bad thoughts and things like that. Which I hadn't, you know, anything to make up for to go to confession.

OD: And if you had said no to confession and no to Mass, was that an option?

TY: I don't know. I don't think so, I think everybody just agreed.

OD: Okay.

TY: And Sister W was the one who looked after the babies, and Mother – you called her Mother W– you called them all Mother.

OD: Was that W?

TY: *Spells the sister's name*. I think. That's what I've always called her, W.

OD: Sure.

TY: And Mother H– she was called Mother W, Mother H, she was a sister – she was the midwife, Mother H was the midwife who, after you had your baby, two

days I spend in *name of hospital* and then you were brought back to the mother and baby home, and she did all the necessary checking your stitches and all that sort of thing and...

OD: So, she was a midwife?

TY: She was a midwife, she did all that.

OD: And that's ... Mother H was the midwife?

TY: Mother H was the midwife, uh-huh. Now she was much stricter than Sister W, but wasn't nasty or unpleasant, you know, she was, but sterner looking. And the day I was leaving, when I was leaving to go up to leave *AD*off in *location*, I was brought into the parlour and given some holy pictures and, you know, a few sort of, I can't remember the words used, but like warnings to behave myself when I got back.

OD: You're not to go back.

TY: Not ... no more sex, more or less. That's what they were saying.

OD: And how did you respond to that?

TY: I had to, they could say what they liked, I was getting out. I was going. Mind you, it was hard to give, just, I remember the nun standing with her in her arms when I was going away, and I couldn't go near her just, you know.

OD: So, when you went to *name of baby home* was that run by nuns?

TY: Same nuns, the same Shepherd Nuns, Good Shepherd Nuns.¹ And they took all your records, and they'd everything there you see. And when AD was looking for me, she was getting all the records from there.

OD: Yeah. But because they had added, because they'd got your name down as *surname* ...

TY: *surname*. It was the two letters you see, didn't ... But she got my maiden name which was *maiden name*, you see, she was able to get that, *full maiden name*. And at the time I had to go into *location* to register *AD*'s birth, right, I had to go into, actually ... to the registry office. And I registered her, and I gave *BF*'s name as her father. Because I remember thinking 'I don't know if he'll still be with me', but I want her to know who her daddy was. Now I remember them taking that, but they did not put, they don't put that on your birth certificate unless the father's with you, which I didn't know. So, I thought when she comes, if she ever does, at least she'd know who her father was. And she didn't know until she came to look for me that I'd married her daddy.

OD: That's amazing.

TY: Which was a great shock for her; a great finding.

OD: I think it's unusual isn't it yeah?

TY: Yeah. Well now, Sister W said quite a few of the girls married the fathers.

OD: Really?

¹ The baby home that TY took her daughter to was actually operated by a separate Order of nuns.

TY: Yeah. Because she would be in touch with a few of them from *Good Shepherd mother and baby home*. You know, a few kept in touch with her.

OD: Yeah. So, if you had changed your mind, what do you think would have happened? So, say you had decided to keep the baby, would they have been supportive of that?

TY: The nuns?

OD: Yeah.

TY: Yeah they offered to keep her 'til I married *BF*.

OD: Oh of course, you said, yeah.

TY: They said, they says: "We'll look after her 'til you can decide what you're going to do." They offered to do that, and I just says: "No, I can't tell Daddy". But they did offer that. They were very accommodating that way.

OD: Why do you think they were so accommodating to you?

TY: Well, I don't know whether they were the same with everybody.

OD: So, it wasn't, because I know you said the room and stuff...

TY: Well, I thought, it was only afterward I thought 'I wonder was it because I was educated?' And they let me go back after three and a half weeks. But a lot of those girls, their parents had put them in there. Now there was one girl when

I arrived there, I was twenty-one, I'd just turned twenty-one, and she was thirty. And she had a baby of three months, I remember. Her name was *name* and he was called *name*. And he was gorgeous, he was three months old. And I remember asking Sister W, years afterwards when I went to visit her:

“Whatever happened to *name of the 30-year-old*?” And she says: “Name of 30-year-old* was from a small village in Ireland, and she stayed with the nuns for a full year in the hope that the father would marry her, and he didn’t.” And she’d to give that baby up at a year old.

OD: But they let her stay.

TY: They let her stay, so.

OD: Wow, that’s really sad.

TY: And there was, I remember another girl there from *location*, a very good-looking girl with auburn hair. She was beautiful. And you didn’t talk much about your past or anything, you know, everything was sort of, you weren’t told not to, but nobody did just. And this girl, I remember her saying: “My worry is not giving up my baby, my worry is going home with no money. My mother thinks I’m working and I’m getting money to bring home to her, and I haven’t a penny to bring home.” And it’s funny, my sister, I was - Mum thought I was working too, and I always sent her money home in the summer, that’s what you did. And I didn’t have any money really, and my sister gave me money, I think it was something like forty pounds, which was a lot then, to bring home to mum and dad. But this girl, that was her only worry: “What am I gonna tell them?”

OD: So, there were clearly girls there who were terrified of their parents, and luckily you weren’t.

TY: No. And I remember *AD* came back, and luckily Mummy and Daddy were still alive, so were *BF*'s parents, and Mummy said: "If I had known that child was over there I'd have gone straight over there and brought her home." And I said: "I know you would have, Mummy, but I just couldn't tell Dad."

OD: So how was that, when you told them finally?

TY: Oh, well we met *AD*, we met her on the *date*, the week after we knew she was looking for us.

OD: And this is *year*?

TY: This is '*year*. The *date* the Friday, my sister got the letter. I wrote to *AD* on the Sunday, sat down at the table on Mother's Day and wrote her a letter. The social worker met her on the, no, we met the social worker on the Monday. *BF* was working *workplace* and we met her in one of the huts there ... she came up to there, we met with her [the social worker].

OD: Wow.

TY: And I gave her the letter for *AD* and a photograph of her sister and brothers. A photograph of us. And the social worker gave me photographs of *AD*. And I'm looking at her thinking 'oh my god', you know, trying to think who she was like and all the rest of it. And then the social worker met *AD* on the Wednesday I think, gave her my letter and the photographs, and said: "Yeah she does want to meet you." And she says: "Right I'll meet her on Saturday, *location*."

OD: So that was a week.

TY: A week from, I remember the night that we heard, *BF* came in from, from Friday night. And I always did eggs and beans and chips. That was the Friday night for the kids, right, they got that eggs and beans and chips, homemade chips, on a Friday night. And they all came in, *BF* would've gave them a lift from school. And he, they, I had nothing ready because I'd been on to my sister, and she'd told me, and of course I'd cried my eyes out and all. And Mother's Day was the Sunday, remember this was the Friday

"What's happened? Oh Mummy [said her children]"

... And here's me to *BF*: "Come into the room, I've got a Mother's Day present."

Of course, he was all laughing and rolling his eyes and all. And I told him. And his words were "*TY* our lives will never be the same again." And that frightened me. Everything. "What do you mean? What do you mean? ... It'll never be the same again." I thought, 'God, like, no no ...' And we were to go to a dinner party that night, which I eventually went to, but it was teeming rain, and *BF* says: "We need to go out for a walk." So, we said to the kids: "We're going out for a walk."

"In the rain?"

"Yeah, we'll be back in an hour."

Out for a walk and just try to get our head round it. You know, couldn't.

Couldn't imagine what it was going to be like. And the day we met her, we met her then the next week, in *location*, in the *hotel name* That's where we met her. And the social worker walked in with her. We'd to meet her at two o'clock, we were there about half one, we didn't want to be late. And when she walked in with the social worker, I remember walking over and of course hugging her, and I was crying, and her, afterwards, patting my back said: "There, there, now that'll do you" [laughs]. And *BF* was just going with me, he was just sitting

there looking at her. He just couldn't take his eyes off her. And I couldn't believe it like, because he had hitched down to *location* when I was in the hospital to see her, and had actually held her. So...

OD: That's probably why he was a bit, I don't know obsessed in the beginning, because he knew.

TY: Yeah, which was nice to us to be able to tell her that, you know, that he'd actually held his wee baby. So that was nice, it was something else. But she says she didn't know. And I said: "Oh, why did you not know?" She says: "Because, when the social worker told me that you'd married my father, and that you'd a girl and two boys, all I could think of was my sister will hate me. She's been an only girl.' But then, of course, *youngest daughter's name* wasn't spoiled like *AD* was spoiled. So, you know.

OD: I was the only girl and I would've loved a sister, so.

TY: Yeah.

OD: So, I think most girls would love that.

TY: Yeah, and the boys, we told ... we took we used to ... when we wanted to tell them anything, or tell them off or anything, *BF* used to take them on a walk around the road in the country, right. The walk and the talk. So, we waited until *youngest daughter's name* came back that Easter holidays, because it was just the next two weeks or something. We'd met *AD* on the *date*, the children didn't know, we didn't know whether ... *BF* says: "Now *TY*, she mightn't wanna have anything to do with us. She might wanna just meet us and go away, you've gotta be prepared for that."

Here's me: "No, she'll want to be part of the family"; thinking it would be all easy-peasy. No idea what it was gonna mean.

But she says: "Oh I want it all.

Here's me: "What?

"I want it all. I want to meet all the family, I want to meet my grandparents."

And all I can think of was "I've gotta tell them." After all this I have to tell Mummy and Daddy. Oh my god. And *BF*'s parents. I'm gonna have to tell them. So, all I could think of, and my friends, and people I work with. But everybody was wonderful, they just thought it was a super story, you know.

OD: I think the story itself is so ingenious and well executed.

TY: And Mummy and Daddy were wonderful. I told Mummy up at my sister's first, my other sister... and she ...said: "Sure, come up and tell Mummy first, and then we'll tell Daddy." So, I had brought *AD*'s photos up. Mummy says – now [I] held the photograph, and I said: "Who do you think that is?"

Immediately says: "That's one of your Aunt W's daughters." [Aunt W was my Daddy's sister]. I says: "No it's not Mummy."

"That's them 'uns, your Aunt W."

I says: "No". I says: "Actually, it's mine."

She says: "What?"

And I told her. And her words to me were: "How did you go through that without me?"

OD: Yeah. I think it's amazing.

TY: Wasn't that wonderful?

OD: Yeah.

TY: And I says: “Oh Mummy, but I’ve to tell Daddy”

“I’ll tell him.”

I says: “No, I have to tell him myself.”

And he was deaf at this stage, you had to shout at the top of your voice. The whole of the flats would’ve heard me. And she says: “Write it down, write it down.” And I’ve still got the wee piece of paper. And I wrote down ‘Daddy, twenty-six years ago I got pregnant to *BF*.’ I made sure I put *BF*, so he knew it was *BF*. ‘And I had a baby girl, and she has come back.’ So, I went down, and I was his favourite you see too. That was another thing, I was the youngest girl, so I was his favourite. So I went down there with Mummy and he said: “Awk’ - and my nickname was *nickname*, - “awk it’s *nickname*, come in!” And he’s all smiles and all and I says: “I’ve some, sit down, there’s something I want you to read.” And he looked and he said: “Well, it’s your writing.” And he looked at it, and he looked at me, he looked at it again, he looked at me. And looked again and he started to cry.

OD: When your dad cries it’s just...

TY: Oh God, it is. And I said, his birthday, that was the middle of *date*, his birthday was the *date*, and he was gonna be eighty that year. And I says: “She’s coming back for your birthday.” And he says: “Well that’d be the best birthday present I’ve ever had.”

OD: Aw, oh.

TY: So, it was great like. They were just wonderful, and *BF*’s parents were the same, I mean they ... And I always say, well, I say, I always, we always thought of her [adoptive] mum and dad with affection and love, you know.

She's given her love, she's looking after her. We always thought of her like that, never resented her or anything like that. I know she's getting spoiled by her, we've given her a baby that she can't have. You know, that's the way you dealt with it in your head. But the one thing, Olivia, you didn't get then was counselling. When I think back on it, really, you know, going through that you should've had a course of counselling, which nobody did then anyway. Do you know what I mean, in those days, you know, there was, it wasn't ...

OD: There was no understanding.

TY: No understanding of it.

OD: Did the nuns offer you anything? Did they, were they able to give you anything when...?

TY: No, there was nothing like that. No, you were looked after, you, and all of it.

OD: Was there anything missing, do you think, from that experience with the nuns? Was there anything that...?

TY: Well, I, there could've been. But at that stage you were just, you know, you'd blinkers on, you were just getting through your day, getting through your week.

OD: So, there was nothing that was too difficult, no chores or anything that were too hard?

TY: No. We'd to polish the floors and do a bit of window cleaning. But, you know there's - we were allowed to watch TV at times. I remember watching, that was *date*, all the trouble in Derry, the start of the Troubles, I remember watching that on television. I remember watching Top of the Pops. So really, you know, you were allowed to watch some television. And, like, I can't remember what time we went to bed, but you were probably getting into bed. Do you know? You're pregnant, or you're getting up during the night if you're gonna treat your baby and stuff.

OD: And if you'd needed medical help or anything.

TY: Oh yeah, it was, you got that because I remember going into labour the week before I had *AD*. I took pains and stuff and they got the ambulance and I was taken into thing. But I was there a day or so, and I was obviously not; the baby wasn't ready to come. So, I came out again. And then the following week I went into labour, the ambulance took you straight there, and, I mean the attention you got at the hospital was like any. But I remember, then you sat down in the common room to feed your baby, right. And I remember a ring that I had, put on this left hand like this as if it was a wedding ring, do you know? All the other women, but they must've known that the girls from *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* came there. And I think I told somebody my husband was in the Army. I think I told them, that was why I wasn't getting visited from, from him you know. You know, you told all, it was all, like, the pretence you know, so...

OD: So where did you get the ring from, was it just one that you had or did someone give it to you?

TY: It was one that I had. It was one that, my sister *name of eldest sister* gave me it or something actually. Oh yes, it was the one that my sister *name of eldest sister* had given me. A previous boyfriend, and she, now she was with *name of sister's boyfriend* and she was married and she'd given me the ring. It was a ring I had, you know, that I turned round.

OD: Got it.

TY: But they knew, I'm sure, all the women. And nobody ever asked you questions, they always seen you, I was one of the girls from the, the home that came in and had your baby. It was only afterwards I thought that. But, no, the nuns that were there, they definitely were, they weren't obstructive to me anyway. And as I say, I kept in touch with Sister W, she was such a, she was so lovely, and I got a card from her every Christmas and I'd go up and see her every year.

OD: Is she still...?

TY: Yeah.

OD: Oh yes, you said, yeah ...

TY: She's up there. And I went up last year, and I, she's from the south, she's actually very well connected with, who is she related to now? Because I've a cousin, when she was up in *location* in the mother and baby, or, not the mother and baby homes up there, but helping out up there in that district before she moved up to the *location* again. My cousin used to do voluntary work, help her. She's very well connected politically, down south. So, her ninetieth birthday was down in the *location and year* and I got the date and I sent her a

card of course down to there, and she said she was able to tell them all who that was from and all the rest of it; my story and all, you know. But she's lovely, and she's just alive, and I go up. And every time I go up she'll say: "Tell the nuns what it was like." You know, she wants me to tell the rest of them that they were good to me. Do you know? There was no abuse, there was no nastiness. As I say, you had to go to Mass and you had to go to confession but, do you know? There was no hardship really.

OD: Would you have had to do that at home? Were your parents religious?

TY: Well, you'd have had to go to Mass every Sunday. And you used to have to go to confession, like, you would've been sent off to confession, sometimes you went, sometimes you didn't bother going. You let on you did, came back home and said yeah you were... "Who, what priest was on?"

"Father so-and-so." Because you knew, you know, so ...

OD: I just have a couple more questions.

TY: No problem.

OD: Yeah, I'll just make sure how we're doing for time. Ooh, sorry, it's really interesting.

TY: Yeah okay.

OD: Just a couple more questions. The first one was, why did you want, kind of, your story to be part of this project? I just ask everyone that.

TY: Well, there's so much bad press about the mother and baby homes, and rightly so if that was the case, which it obviously was. I saw the film *The Magdalene Laundries*, and look at the case in Galway with all those babies buried. There must've been something happening there. They couldn't all have died, do you know? So when the nun from *location* asked me if I'd be interested, I said: "Certainly." And I always would have been willing to do that, and *BF* was behind me in that too. And I told *AD* I was doing that as well so, and my other, the rest of my family I told them. Yeah, they said: "That's great, mum, yeah so you should."

OD: So, was that Sister W asked you to...?

TY: Yes. One of the nuns, not her in particular but she, obviously the nun, Sister F is it? Sister

OD: F?

TY: Yeah, F. Thank God, I remember there. It was her, she phoned me.

OD: From *location*?

TY: ... yeah, uh-huh. Yeah. She actually phoned me when I was away on a ... trip with the girls, and, I mean all my friends know too, you know. And *AD* has met them all and...

OD: And they love them?

TY: What?

OD: And they love them?

TY: They do, they think it's great, you know. Which is wonderful, because you always thought [gasps] 'what will they think of me after doing that? How could they think that anybody could do that?' But they were all...

OD: I think most people are more understanding than people would expect.

TY: Yeah, they were.

OD: Especially now.

TY: Very supportive.

OD: So, you, kind of, then wanted to add a positive experience to everything.

TY: Yes.

OD: Just to, sort of, say...

TY: I did, because mine was, as I said, we had clean bedding, clean rooms, you're fed your three meals a day. I don't remember going hungry, I don't remember being cold or miserable, and the few chores you did, I don't remember thinking 'I can't do this anymore.' You did a bit of polishing floors, or plenty of, or cleaning the windows, or dusting, or, it wasn't, you know it wasn't hard work. And the nuns were very helpful as regards to letting me phone home, letting *BF* write to me, offering to look after *AD*. You know, all those things.

OD: I think that's really, really interesting that you're... I think your whole, your whole, kind of, story from the beginning to the end, points towards you just trying to get towards that end goal of, like, I need to be able to get back to where I was.

TY: Back to normal life.

OD: And they helped you.

TY: It was back to, you know. And I loved university, and I really loved that I was such a know-all, and I used to come home, thought I knew everything, you know, after a year, like. But I just loved it. Because *name of university* ... And the lecturers and all came to our parties. Do you know? Everybody went to the same party, you know. And they were all, it was all very much fun and very friendly. And I, I organised our twenty-fifth reunion and our fortieth and our fiftieth. Fiftieth was our *date*. I organised that When I started, I started in 196*, BF started the year after me ...and then I got pregnant and had her in '*date*'. So, and there were, what, twenty or something at our, we went back to *name of university* you know. So, and they all knew that I'd had the baby, you see. And when I came back then they all knew, but they were all, it was great to get me back and all, so.

OD: Yeah, I think it sounds, I mean, just how hard you've worked to get back to it. I'm glad that you had a good experience...

TY: ... Experience, I know, I did!

OD: Sounds like you really deserve it.

TY: I know. And, funnily, that, that was in, I was back on the *date*. So, uni for the ... there was only ten-week terms then at *name of university*, So very short. So, I think we broke up, say the middle of December, for Christmas. And I remember *BF* and I, up in *location* one day, and he says, and, ... no just before that, he says: "Let's get engaged TY." And I says: "Alright". Of course, that was great. So he actually said to his mother that morning: 'I'm going to ... get engaged' - she'd never met me - "... could you give me any money?" And she gave him, she'd never met me, she didn't know, this was the first she knew that he was going with a girl. So, we got engaged that Saturday, and I remember saying: "Oh *BF*, there's Christmas coming up on our wee baby's sitting up there, what are we going to do?"

He says: "We'll go up now and we'll bring her out if you want to do that." And we went up to the mother and baby, we brought a wee teddy, but she'd been adopted. And, actually, I was relieved. Because what was I gonna, I was gonna come out, then, with a baby, do you know? But I, you know, was sitting thinking 'oh God ... what have I done? What have I done here?'

OD: Oh, that's such a heart-breaking...

TY: Yeah. But I was actually relieved of it. Somebody actually wanted her. I was thinking she'd be up there and nobody would want her.

OD: Yeah.

TY: And next, I knew, I found out then the next day she was adopted, they'd obviously had her earmarked for *adoptive parents names* ...

OD: And how, how, oh sorry carry on...

TY: we got to her Daddy's funeral, you see. Her Daddy died on the *date*, the same day as one of my sisters, unfortunately. But we went down to her Daddy's funeral, *BF* and I, and we sent, we gave lilies, and she put one of our lilies on her Daddy's grave. We were standing there, it was really weird. It was like, *BF* said, it was like watching his own funeral, you know. And we went to the, after, we met her mother's sister, and she said: “*adoptive mother's name* would have loved you. She'd have loved this.”

And I says: That's good to hear.”

She says: “She would've been so pleased that you, that *AD* found you.’

And we kept, we still keep in touch with them. Her cousins and all too. And her brother, we met her, then her brother, and her brother's wife and kids, and I would be in touch with them as well. And *AD* still keeps in touch with them, her adopted brother and all, which is good too, you know, that's...

OD: It's a really, it's a really, kind of, I know it had, kind of, a family death, and that's always so tragic.

TY: Yeah.

OD: But it sounds like, at least with regards to your relationship, everything worked out in a way.

TY: It did, it, a big story, there was so much in it, you know.

OD: Yeah, but it all came back to you being reunited, but being reunited at the right time I suppose.

TY: Yep, yeah.

OD: Do you have anything else you want to say?

TY: No, I think, as I say, my experience in *Good Shepherd mother and baby home*, certainly, it wasn't unpleasant from what they were offering me. And I remember just thinking, just, I didn't even know what, and I was gonna, like, just get through this. And I think the fact that *BF* was there for me was everything, you know. That he was able to write to me.

OD: You had a support system.

TY: Yeah. And, actually, one of the, between those few weeks – I was there probably about six weeks altogether, something like that, maybe a couple of months at the most – my sister and her husband came down to visit me, and the nuns allowed them to take me out, and they'd actually brought *BF* down, and he was left at a bus stop, and him and I had a wee day together at the bus stop, so.

OD: And do you think the nuns knew about this?

TY: No, I don't think they did, no. I don't think they knew about that.

OD: And so how long have you been together now?

TY: We've been together. We met on the, we always, it was just the start of, *date*.

OD: Wow.

TY: Yeah, that's when we met.

OD: And have you had a big celebration?

TY: Yes, we did.

OD: Good.

TY: Yeah, told all our friends. You know. We married in 197*...

OD: Well congratulations.

TY: Thank you.

OD: So, if you're happy, I'll switch off there.

TY: Yes, that's great Olivia.

[END OF INTERVIEW].